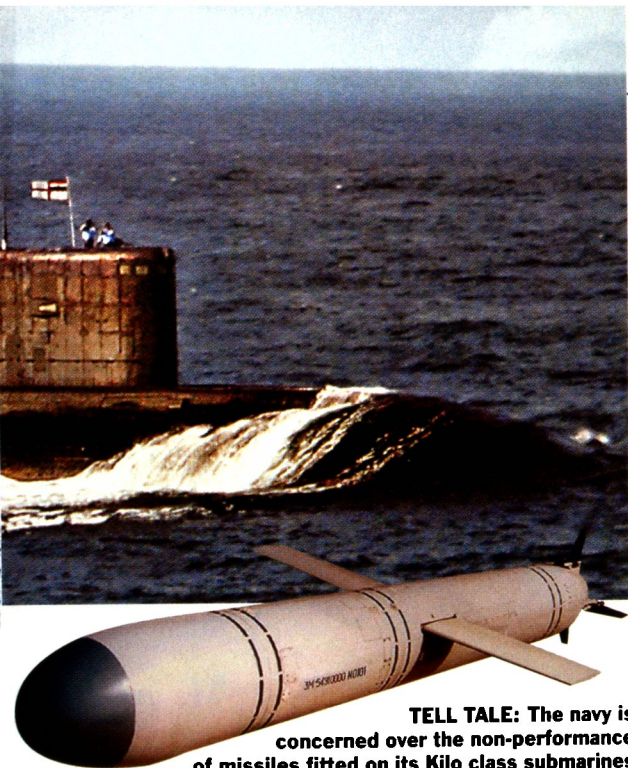




TELL TALE: The navy is concerned over the non-performance of missiles fitted on its Kilo class submarines

ever, the navy has been plagued with a series of misfires from anti-ship variants of the missile fired from Kilo class submarine. Now the non-performance of the land-attack variant has only added to the navy's worries: it bought 28 of them from Russia in 2006 for Rs 844 crore. "Unsatisfactory performance by contractors is not a new phenomenon," says Rear Admiral (retired) Raja Menon. "It cannot be said to be a failure on the part of the navy because it runs tough contracts," he added. However, the glitches are significant because they are one in a series of technical defects, which have surfaced in Russian-origin equipment in the past few years.

Analysts say this is due to a change in the way equipment is now being purchased from Russia. Earlier, most military equipment saw extensive service in the Soviet Union and was then exported to client states like India. This changed after the breakup of the Soviet Union and with the bankruptcy of its military. Its vast military industrial complex lost its largest buyer and operator. The Indian Navy was the first customer for many systems like the upgraded IL-38, the Talwar class frigates, Klub missiles and Ka-31 AEW helicopters. It now seems to be paying the price for inadequately tested equipment. While it is not clear where the problem with this variant of the missile is, the navy believes it lies in the submarine's gyro, which feeds in the crucial parameters into the missile before it is launched. The gyro is also believed to be at the heart of the problems in the anti-ship variants of the Klub.

The navy is planning to install French-built inertial navigation systems in Kilo class submarines to replace the Russian-built systems. "If the problems persist, we may have to consider replacing the Klub with other options," said a defence ministry official. Part of the shopping list during navy chief Sureesh Mehta's visit to Israel was to explore other options. Replacing it, however, is considered as the last option as it involves extensive rewiring of the entire submarine fleet. Until then, the winter of discontent with Russia continues. ■

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